THEME 4

On the Interpretation of Art Works

Our previous Theme considered the nature of art and its value. However, often underlying our assessments of art are questions of interpretation. What does a work of art actually *mean?* Should we look for meaning at all? And where and how should we look for it? Can works of art carry moral meanings? These questions are our focus in this Theme.

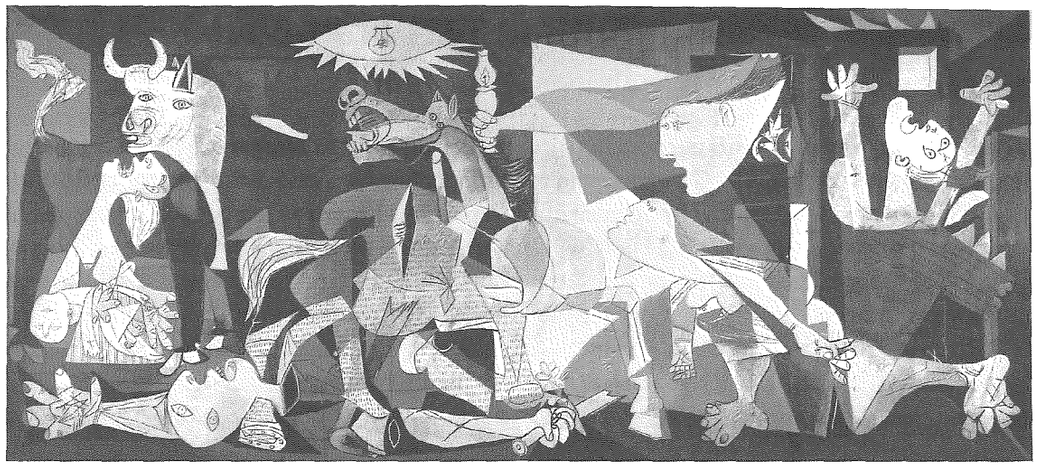
As with our previous Theme, it will be useful to draw on any experiences of art available to you. The term 'art' covers a multitude of forms, including novels, poetry, plays, songs, all styles of music, dance, sculpture, installation, film, photography, graphic design, architecture, painting, drawing and animation. Reflecting on your past and present encounters with these artforms, as well as organising new experiences of art – such as a visit to a local gallery – will enhance your philosophical exploration of how we find meaning in art.

Introductory Activities

DO

Working by yourself, study the following image and write your own answers to the questions beneath.

1. Describe what you see in this painting.
2. What do you think the artist is trying to depict in this painting?
3. Does this painting have a particular point of view? Could it be said that this painting contains an argument? Why or why not?
4. Do you recognise this painting and its artist? How does that recognition – or lack thereof – affect the way you approach the image?



Pablo Picasso's *Guernica* (1937) is among the most famous paintings of the twentieth century. Picasso created it during the Spanish Civil War in response to the bombings of a small town named Guernica in northern Spain.

The painting is generally interpreted as a depiction of the suffering which war inflicts upon innocent civilians. It has become world famous as an indictment of war.

But is this the only interpretation possible? And is it the only correct interpretation?

If you are encountering *Guernica* for the first time, what do you see? Do you see images of war, terror, violence, chaos and suffering? Do you read a political message? If you see something quite different from the orthodox interpretation of this work, who is to say yours is not a valid interpretation, an equally important way of finding meaning in this artwork?

And what is the status of the view communicated by Picasso's painting? Is this just as powerful an indictment of war as a philosophical argument for pacifism? Or can it be said that Picasso has produced a philosophical argument – and if so, what are its premises and conclusions?

THINK

Can art be philosophy? Can it be said to produce arguments? Can you think of other relevant examples to draw into this discussion?

Art and Moral Meanings

Art and Moral Improvement

Ethics and aesthetics each deal with the assessment of kinds of value, and the two areas have intertwined throughout their history.

As we have seen, artworks such as *Guernica* may seem to impart clear moral messages. But should we find persuasive the moral stance taken by a work of art?

Guernica is often spoken of as an internationally recognised anti-war symbol. Yet for its artist to be seen as any kind of moral leader would strike many as horrifying if not obscene. Picasso's personal life celebrated selfish excess, infidelity and exploitation. His misogyny was well known. Two of his former lovers killed themselves and several other mistresses languished in poverty despite his immense wealth.

But, as any committed anti-intentionalist will object, an artist's biography is irrelevant when assessing the meaning and impact of the artwork. The work must stand alone.

Aristotle believed art had an important place in society for its capacity to purify emotions. *Catharsis* could be achieved, and extreme emotions and passions brought into healthy balance, by witnessing tragic narrative – in an epic poem or play, for example.

For Russian novelist and art theorist, Leo Tolstoy (1828-1910), art should be assessed on the basis of its transmission of feelings of brotherhood. In *What is Art* (1897), he argues, in essence, that art ought to make us better people:

> *The destiny of art in our time is to transmit from the realm of reason to the realm of feeling the truth that well-being for men consists in their being united together, and to set up, in place of the existing realm of force, that kingdom of God – that is, of love.*[54]

Along not dissimilar lines, the writer C.S. Lewis argues that the imaginative world of literature enables us to get beyond our own limited worldview and see things through the experiences of others, thus fostering empathy:

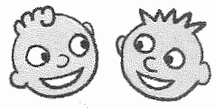
> *We want to see with other eyes, to imagine with other imaginations, to feel with other hearts, as well as with our own… One of the things we feel after reading a great work is 'I have got out'. Or from another point of view, 'I have got in'; pierced the shell of some other monad and discovered what it is like inside.* [55]

For novelist and philosopher Iris Murdoch (Famous Philosopher File p.560), great art has edifying powers – that is, the capacity to improve us morally – on many levels. She argues that by taking us into experiences outside our everyday concerns, art 'pierces the veil' of our selfishness, and expands our perspective. We are led by art to greater clarity of vision, while cultivating certain virtues such as loving attention to others. In addition, the wisdom and insight of great artists can redirect our moral compasses towards an absolute Good. Murdoch is aligned with Plato is arguing that we can appreciate absolute concepts of Truth, Beauty, and moral rightness, and she believes that great art offers special insights to these things:

> *Art and morals are, with certain provisos…one. Their essence is the same. The essence of both of them is love… Love is the extremely difficult realisation that something other than oneself is real. Love, and so art and morals, is the discovery of reality.*[56]

History tells us that art has indeed made important moral contributions. Artwork and aesthetics played key roles in the case against slavery in Britain, for example. Sometimes art makes us think about entrenched dogmas and unexamined assumptions, and for many people one of the primary functions of art in society is to challenge the status quo. Perhaps you can reflect on examples in your own life, when seeing a film, reading a book, or viewing a piece of graphic art, has influenced your thinking on some moral question.

54 Leo Tolstoy, *What is Art,* http://archive.org/stream/whatisart00tolsuoft/whatisart00tolsuoft_djvu.txt (accessed September 3rd, 2013)
55 C.S.Lewis, 2006, *An Experiment in Criticism,* Cambridge University Press, Cambridge, p. 137.
56 Iris Murdoch, 'The Sublime and the Good' 1959, in Conradi 1997, p.215.



DISCUSS

1. Can art make us better people? Consider examples such as *Guernica* and other relevant songs, books, plays, films or images with which you are familiar.
2. Which arguments considered above do you find most convincing on the question of whether art makes us better people?

TEXT STUDY: Iris Murdoch, *The Sovereignty of Good and Other Concepts* (1970)

[see Useful Resources]

READ from pp.84-89.

1. What does Murdoch mean by 'unselfing'?
2. How can appreciation of good art assist us to 'unself'?
3. What does Murdoch mean when she suggests that much art is actually 'self-consoling fanstasy'?
4. What does Murdoch mean when she describes the 'pointlessness' of human life? Why does she think a realisation of this pointlessness is embodied in great art?
5. To what extent is Murdoch's account of the links between ethics and aesthetics a convincing one?

FAMOUS PHILOSOPHER FILE

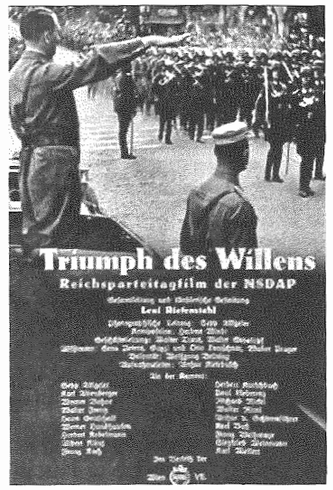
Iris Murdoch (1919–1999)

Iris Murdoch was born in Dublin but grew up in London and attended Oxford University, where she studied philosophy and classics. In her twenties she worked for the United Nations in Europe, assisting refugees, before commencing postgraduate studies in philosophy at Cambridge University. She then took up the academic post at Oxford which she would retain for the next two decades. At age 35 she published the first of her 26 novels, having also published numerous articles in philosophy, and the first English-language book on French philosopher Jean-Paul Sartre. Murdoch married English literature professor and novelist John Bayley, and their life together was chronicled in the film, *Iris* (2001), including her tragic degeneration in the grip of Alzheimer's disease from 1995 onwards.

Murdoch is often spoken of as a neo-Platonist, such was the influence of Plato on her work. Other influences included Simone Weil, Wittgenstein and Sartre. Murdoch's novels explored sexual relationships, morality and the unconscious, and she also wrote several plays. *The Sovereignty of Good* (1970) and *Metaphysics as a Guide to Morals* (1992) are her most celebrated works of philosophy.

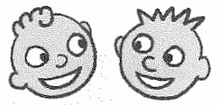
Art and Moral Depravity

Triumph of the Will (1935) is a film made by Leni Riefenstahl, depicting the 1934 Nazi Party Congress in Nuremburg, which was attended by hundreds of thousands of cheering Nazi supporters. The film presents Adolf Hitler as a mighty and heroic figure. Indeed, as Hitler commissioned the film and was its unofficial executive producer, it may be considered Nazi propaganda.



Brilliant, depraved or both? Movie poster for Nazi film, *Triumph of the Will*, crediting its director and cameramen.

Yet *Triumph of the Will* is also widely praised for its brilliance as an example of cinema for its era: it is full of original techniques such as moving cameras, distorted effects, aerial photography, and showcases a revolutionary marriage of music and cinematography, all of which have been highly influential. These elements would be sufficient in other cases for a film to be described as 'great art' and perhaps to place this film among the greatest in history. Certainly the film won a multitude of international awards in its time. But can a work which valorises the evils of Nazism be considered 'great'?



DISCUSS

1. Should *Triumph of the Will* be considered a great work of art?
2. We are all familiar with films and stories which depict reprehensible characters in appealing ways (for example, *Silence of the Lambs; The Sopranos*... Can you think of more?). Is art which reflects 'good' more worthy than that which reflects 'evil'?

3

The Sovereignty of Good Over Other Concepts

We are anxiety-ridden animals. Our minds are continually active, fabricating an anxious, usually self-preoccupied, often falsifying *veil* which partially conceals the world. Our states of consciousness differ in quality, our fantasies and reveries are not trivial and unimportant, they are profoundly connected with our ener-gies and our ability to choose and act. And if quality of consciousness matters, then anything which alters con-sciousness in the direction of unselfishness, objectivity and realism is to be connected with virtue.

Following a hint in Plato (*Phaedrus* 250) I shall start by speaking of what is perhaps the most obvious thing in our surroundings which is an occasion for 'unselfing', and that is what is popularly called beauty. Recent philosophers tend to avoid this term because they prefer to talk of reasons rather than of experiences. But the implication of experience with beauty seems to me to be something of great importance which should not be by-passed in favour of analysis of critical vocabularies. Beauty is the convenient and traditional name of something which art and nature share, and which gives a fairly clear sense to the idea of quality of experience and change of consciousness. I am looking out of my window in an anxious and resentful state of mind, oblivious of my surroundings, brooding perhaps on some damage done to my prestige. Then suddenly I observe a hovering kestrel. In a moment everything is altered. The brooding self with its hurt vanity has disappeared. There is nothing now but kestrel. And when I return to thinking of the other matter it seems less important. And of course this is something which we may also do deliberately: give attention to nature in order to clear our minds of selfish care. It may seem odd to start the argument against what I have roughly labelled as 'romanticism' by using the case of attention to

nature. In fact I do not think that any of the great romantics really believed that we receive but what we give and in our life alone does nature live, although the lesser ones tended to follow Kant's lead and use nature as an occasion for exalted self-feeling. The great romantics, including the one I have just quoted, transcended 'romanticism'. A self-directed enjoyment of nature seems to me to be something forced. More naturally, as well as more properly, we take a self-forgetful pleasure in the sheer alien pointless independent existence of animals, birds, stones and trees. 'Not how the world is, but that it is, is the mystical.'

I take this starting-point, not because I think it is the most important place of moral change, but because I think it is the most accessible one. It is so patently a good thing to take delight in flowers and animals that people who bring home potted plants and watch kestrels might even be surprised at the notion that these things have anything to do with virtue. The surprise is a product of the fact that, as Plato pointed out, beauty is the only spiritual thing which we love by instinct. When we move from beauty in nature to beauty in art we are already in a more difficult region. The experience of art is more easily degraded than the experience of nature. A great deal of art, perhaps most art, actually is self-consoling fantasy, and even great art cannot guarantee the quality of its consumer's consciousness. However, great art exists and is sometimes properly experienced and even a shallow experience of what is great can have its effect. Art, and by 'art' from now on I mean good art, not fantasy art, affords us a pure delight in the independent existence of what is excellent. Both in its genesis and its enjoyment it is a thing totally opposed to selfish obsession. It invigorates our best faculties and, to use Platonic language, inspires love in the highest part of the soul. It is able to do this partly by virtue of something which it shares with nature: a perfection of form which invites unpossessive contemplation

and resists absorption into the selfish dream life of the consciousness.

Art however, considered as a sacrament or a source of good energy, possesses an extra dimension. Art is less accessible than nature but also more edifying since it is actually a human product, and certain arts are actually 'about' human affairs in a direct sense. Art is a human product and virtues as well as talents are required of the artist. The good artist, in relation to his art, is brave, truthful, patient, humble; and even in non-representational art we may receive intuitions of these qualities. One may also suggest, more cautiously, that non-representational art does seem to express more positively something which is to do with virtue. The spiritual role of music has often been acknowledged, though theorists have been chary of analysing it. However that may be, the representational arts, which more evidently hold the mirror up to nature, seem to be concerned with morality in a way which is not simply an effect of our intuition of the artist's discipline.

These arts, especially literature and painting, show us the peculiar sense in which the concept of virtue is tied on to the human condition. They show us the absolute pointlessness of virtue while exhibiting its supreme importance; the enjoyment of art is a training in the love of virtue. The pointlessness of art is not the pointlessness of a game; it is the pointlessness of human life itself, and form in art is properly the simulation of the self-contained aimlessness of the universe. Good art reveals what we are usually too selfish and too timid to recognize, the minute and absolutely random detail of the world, and reveals it together with a sense of unity and form. This form often seems to us mysterious because it resists the easy patterns of the fantasy, whereas there is nothing mysterious about the forms of bad art since they are the recognizable and familiar rat-runs of selfish day-dream. Good art shows us how difficult it is to be objective by showing us how differently the world looks to an objective vision.

We are presented with a truthful image of the human condition in a form which can be steadily contemplated; and indeed this is the only context in which many of us are capable of contemplating it at all. Art transcends selfish and obsessive limitations of personality and can enlarge the sensibility of its consumer. It is a kind of goodness by proxy. Most of all it exhibits to us the connection, in *human* beings, of clear realistic vision with compassion. The realism of a great artist is not a photographic realism, it is essentially both pity and justice.

Herein we find a remarkable redemption of our tendency to conceal death and chance by the invention of forms. Any story which we tell about ourselves consoles us since it imposes pattern upon something which might otherwise seem intolerably chancy and incomplete. However, human life is chancy and incomplete. It is the role of tragedy, and also of comedy, and of painting to show us suffering without a thrill and death without a consolation. Or if there is any consolation it is the austere consolation of a beauty which teaches that nothing in life is of any value except the attempt to be virtuous. Masochism is the artist's greatest and most subtle enemy. It is not easy to portray death, real death, not fake prettified death. Even Tolstoy did not really manage it in *Ivan Ilyich*, although he did elsewhere. The great deaths of literature are few, but they show us with an exemplary clarity the way in which art invigorates us by a juxtaposition, almost an identification, of pointlessness and value. The death of Patroclus, the death of Cordelia, the death of Petya Rostov. All is vanity. The only thing which is of real importance is the ability to see it all clearly and respond to it justly which is inseparable from virtue. Perhaps one of the greatest achievements of all is to join this sense of absolute mortality not to the tragic but to the comic. Shallow and Silence. Stefan Trofimovich Verhovensky.

Art then is not a diversion or a side-issue, it is the most

educational of all human activities and a place in which the nature of morality can be *seen*. Art gives a clear sense to many ideas which seem more puzzling when we meet with them elsewhere, and it is a clue to what happens elsewhere. An understanding of any art involves a recognition of hierarchy and authority. There are very evident degrees of merit, there are heights and distances; even Shakespeare is not perfect. Good art, unlike bad art, unlike 'happenings', is something pre-eminently outside us and resistant to our consciousness. We surrender ourselves to its *authority* with a love which is unpossessive and unselfish. Art shows us the only sense in which the permanent and incorruptible is compatible with the transient; and whether representational or not it reveals to us aspects of our world which our ordinary dull dream-consciousness is unable to see. Art pierces the veil and gives sense to the notion of a reality which lies beyond appearance; it exhibits virtue in its true guise in the context of death and chance.

Plato held that beauty could be a starting-point of the good life, but he came to mistrust art and we can see played out in that great spirit the peculiarly distressing struggle between the artist and the saint. Plato allowed to the beauty of the lovely boy an awakening power which he denied to the beauty of nature or of art. He seems to have come to believe that all art is bad art, a mere fiction and consolation which distorts reality. About nature he seems, in the context of the theory of forms, to have been at least once in doubt. Are there forms of mud, hair and dirt? If there are then nature is redeemed into the area of truthful vision. (My previous argument assumes of course, in Platonic terms, that there are.) Another starting-point, or road, which Plato speaks of more often however is the way of the τέχναι, the sciences, crafts, and intellectual disciplines excluding the arts. I think there is a way of the intellect, a sense in which intellectual disciplines are moral disciplines, and this is not too difficult

to discern. There are important bridge ideas between morality and other at first sight different human activities, and these ideas are perhaps most clearly seen in the context of the τέχναι. And as when we use the nature of art as a clue, we may be able to learn more about the central area of morality if we examine what are essentially the same concepts more simply on display elsewhere. I mean such concepts as justice, accuracy, truthfulness, realism, humility, courage as the ability to sustain clear vision, love as attachment or even passion without sentiment or self.

The τέχνη which Plato thought was most important was mathematics, because it was most rigorous and abstract. I shall take an example of a τέχνη more congenial to myself: learning a language. If I am learning, for instance, Russian, I am confronted by an authoritative structure which commands my respect. The task is difficult and the goal is distant and perhaps never entirely attainable. My work is a progressive revelation of something which exists independently of me. Attention is rewarded by a knowledge of reality. Love of Russian leads me away from myself towards something alien to me, something which my consciousness cannot take over, swallow up, deny or make unreal. The honesty and humility required of the student—not to pretend to know what one does not know—is the preparation for the honesty and humility of the scholar who does not even feel tempted to suppress the fact which damns his theory. Of course a τέχνη can be misused; a scientist might feel he ought to give up a certain branch of study if he knew that his discoveries would be used wickedly. But apart from special contexts, studying is normally an exercise of virtue as well as of talent, and shows us a fundamental way in which virtue is related to the real world.